More contradictory behaviour was to follow. After Barahoti, Nehru decided to tentatively raise the border issue. When he met Zhou in Beijing in October 1954, he asked why Chinese maps showed Indian territory as part of China. India's boundaries, he insisted, were fixed, but he wondered, 'Supposing we publish a map showing Tibet as part of India, how would China feel?' Zhou replied soothingly that communist China had not revised its maps and was using the old Kuomintang maps. Beijing needed 'a little time' to publish its new maps. As for India's new maps, Zhou did not raise an objection to them.[15] However, within days of Nehru's return from Beijing, the Chinese embassy in Delhi produced and handed out yet more old Kuomintang maps that incorporated large portions of Indian territory.[16] The embassy's actions suggested that contrary to Zhou's calming remarks at the summit, China affirmed its old Kuomintang maps and rejected India's new 1954 maps.

A similar train of events was to occur in the period from 1956 to 1958. In December 1956–January 1957, Zhou visited India. At his meeting with Nehru, the Chinese premier referred to the McMahon Line during a discussion on Burma. China, he explained, did not like the McMahon Line (which extended into Burma), as this was a legacy of imperial rule. Nonetheless, it would accept the line as a practical matter. Nehru thus assumed that China would also be pragmatic on India's stretch of the McMahon Line. On the western sector, Zhou was silent, despite the publication of India's new maps.

If all this was reassuring to Delhi, there were worrying contradictory signals. In 1956, China had apparently handed out 'thousands' of old maps showing large parts of India as well as Bhutan, Nepal, and Sikkim as part of Chinese territory.[17] Two years later, the Chinese embassy in London distributed the same map. In Delhi's perception, here was a pattern: Zhou reassuring Nehru in Delhi in October 1954 that existing maps were the work of the predecessor Kuomintang government, followed by the distribution of maps that contradicted what he had said; and Zhou again reassuring Nehru in 1956–57 that China would accept the existing boundaries in the eastern sector, even as it hawked around maps